GM ONLY

Running rolls

01

State position and effect, choose consequences, run clocks. Principle: consequences create new situations, not game over.

Position in the tower

POSITION	TYPICAL HERE
Controlled	registered viewing, cover holds, quiet workshop, alert 0–1
Risky	service wing without clearance, gondola in the wind, guards nearby
Desperate	in the open in the sensor corridor, guardian drones firing, Kade in melee, lockdown

Alert itself gives no dice penalty; the changed fiction shifts position and effect.

Consequences

FOUR TYPES

- **Reduced effect:** one effect level less.
- **Complication:** new danger, a door locks, the keycard is moved, Venn gets suspicious. On a clock: minor 1, normal 2, serious 3 segments.
- **Lost opportunity:** the window closes, another method is needed.
- **Harm:** see below.

A complication must not negate a success. Per consequence either resistance or armour. The GM decides whether resistance reduces or avoids, and so sets the tone.

Harm by position

RULE OF THUMB

POSITION	HARM
Controlled	level 1
Risky	level 2
Desperate	level 3 (lethal weapons: up to 4)

The rulebook only states desperate = severe harm; the rest is Blades practice. Temporary states (dazed, panicked) are complications, not harm.

Effect factors

- **Quality:** better gear than the opposition (fine items) = +1.
- **Scale:** group against individuals, drone swarm = ±1.
- **Potency:** weak spot, surprise, magic against the mundane, EMP against drones = +1.

A dominant factor overrides the rest (one against twenty). Zero effect is possible, then only a setup helps.

Clocks

SIZE	FOR
4–5	complex: the keycard lockbox, guards in the service wing
6–7	more complicated: guardian drones, the alert clock
8–10	daunting: break the mana barrier, the vault door without factors

Limited 1 · standard 2 · great 3 segments. Clocks track the obstacle, not the method (“guardian drones”, not “hack the drones”). Simple things need no clock: one roll decides.

Engagement roll

FORTUNE ROLL

1d6, ±1d each: bold / overly complex · the detail hits a weakness / the target is strong against it · contacts help / rivals interfere. Sprawl Whisperer: +1d.

- **6 + 6** first obstacle already overcome, dominant advantage
- **6** dominant advantage or initiative (controlled)
- **4/5** Risky
- **1-3** Desperate

Only holds for the first actions. Don’t describe the approach; cut straight to the first obstacle.

Fortune roll

For uncertainty without a runner action: does Kade notice the outage? Roll a fitting trait (tier, quality, magnitude) or 1–4d6 by situation, ±1d for major advantages and disadvantages. Critical exceptional · 6 good · 4/5 mixed · 1–3 bad.

Dragon’s deals

+1D FOR A CATCH

The GM or anyone at the table may offer one. It happens whatever the roll. Not on top of pushing.

- The invitation is real, but someone recognises your alias.
- Perfect scan, but Venn will remember your face.
- The drone goes offline; its last data burst is already out.
- The gondola gets you there, then locks itself outside.
- You reach the briefcase; the vault door closes behind you.

Flashback prices

0 edge ordinary, 1 complex or unlikely, 2+ elaborate with special opportunities. Then an action roll, a fortune roll or no roll, depending on the danger.

GM ONLY

Combat & opposition

02

Enemies don’t roll. Their behaviour and attacks come out of the runners’ action rolls. Security wants to isolate, hold and buy time; lethal force only on massive escalation.

Gala security

DISCREET · WELL EQUIPPED

- **Goal:** no visible incident in front of the VIPs.
- **Tactics:** address politely, separate, ask aside, escort. Tasers only behind closed doors.
- **Clock:** taking out a pair of guards 4.
- **Harm:** non-lethal, level 1–2.
- **Consequences:** radio call (alert +1), backup, identity recorded.

Dorian Kade

HEAD OF SECURITY

- Cyberarms, wired reflexes, pistol. A master: the GM says what he has already done (gun drawn, exit blocked), and the runners must resist before they can act.
- Openly against him: **desperate**, effect usually limited (quality, reflexes).
- **Clock 6** to bring him down. Better: deceive, distract, avoid him.
- Won’t shoot into a crowd. Keeps incidents small; prefers to pull people into a side room.
- Harm: level 2, with his gun drawn level 3.

Recon drones

SMALL · FAST

- Small frame (–1 scale), flight, sensor array. Observe, capture faces, tag, follow.
- Easy to destroy: one standard hit does it.
- **The danger is the data burst:** alert +1, or a runner’s identity is recorded.
- Intercept it before it reports and the rise is prevented.

Guardian drones

ARMOURED · ARMED

- Medium frame with plating and turret. **Clock 4** per drone (6 at alert 4+).
- Holdout, knives, fists: limited. Brutal weapon, Wreck, EMP: standard or potency.
- **Weak spots:** sensors, weapon module, maintenance port in the drone node.
- **Non-lethal first:** block, taser, containment foam.
- **Lethal** only if the runners are heavily armed or on massive escalation.

Drone escalation

Routine patrol by pattern

Viewing escort, count, compare identities

Irregularity step in between, demand re-auth, block paths, separate

Physical restrain, taser, foam

Weapons only against heavy weapons or massive escalation

External response

FROM ALERT 6

Lots of time left: **response clock 4**. When full, a heavily armed team arrives; escape instead of fighting. Little time: the next big consequence is arriving backup.

Harm in the tower

LEVEL	EXAMPLES
1	cut by glass, twisted ankle, pepper: “sickened”
2	deep cut, concussion after a fall on the stairs
3	shot by a guardian drone, fall through the glass roof
4	only desperate with lethal means

Bangflash, taser jitters, stuck in foam: a temporary complication (dazed, held), not harm.

The bomb in the briefcase

- Only those who open it risk it. Keep it closed and nobody ever learns of it.
- Detect: Survey, Study, Engineer or Interface, depending on method.
- Disarm: risky in calm, desperate under drone fire.
- Detonation: contents destroyed, level 3 harm for the holder (not a death trap), alert rises sharply.

Violence & payoff

- Injured or dead guests or staff: at least as high alert (3 nuyen).
- Venn seriously hurt or killed: breach of contract.
- **Veyrath never fights.** If someone shoots at him, he withdraws.

GM ONLY

Magic in the tower

03

What is magical in the Meridian Spire and what the Awakened can see there. Magic is one more way, never a must: every obstacle can be solved mundanely too.

The vault shell

ORIGINAL CREATION

- Cultivated living tissue inside the walls: dark fibres like roots or muscle.
- Carries a **dual mana barrier**: physical and astral. Astral scouting or passage is severely hampered.
- Reacts to drilling and shocks; small wounds close.
- On alarm the fibres thicken.
- Damage is visible: fibres twitch, dark fluid seeps out.

Getting past the barrier

- **Break through:** clock 8, desperate, each roll alert +1. Loud and slow.
- **Study the door:** Assense or Study at the regular passage shows how the barrier opens in a controlled way. That is a setup: +1 effect or better position for your own way in.
- **Attack the wall:** the tissue reacts, heals, thickens. Damage to the shell counts for Veyrath like damage to the collection.

The astral watcher

OPTIONAL

- Patrols outside the barrier. Not a combat enemy.
- Notices unusual astral activity nearby: **alert +1**.
- That includes spells, sustained assensing, Hush's bright aura.
- Distract it (Assense, Influence) or stay quiet. Banishing focus: potency to drive it off.

What Assense reveals

EFFECT	INSIGHT
Limited	strong magic here; a wall is "alive"; something watches astrally.
Standard	dual barrier, the watcher and its round, the briefcase's aura among the pieces.
Great	how the barrier opens at the passage; which antiques are magical; the barrier is old and costly, no corp builds this for art.

Magic in the hoard

- **The briefcase:** faint, old, harmless aura. Stands out to the Awakened, triggers nothing.
- **Magical antiques:** distinguishable from merely expensive pieces. One is temptingly easy to take. No trap.

Spells in practice

- **Stunbolt** on a guard: Assense, risky, silent, non-lethal. A guard is weak: cost 1 edge or drain 1. Near level 110 the watcher notices.
- **Veil:** people see the illusion, **cameras see the truth**. Needs concentration; when challenged, re-roll Assense or the veil drops.
- The spell's signature clings to caster's spot and target for minutes and can be tracked.

Magical consequences

- **Drain** comes from the spell cost (spell potential = Assense rating, Ravn 1): below it 1 edge or drain 1, equal 1 edge + drain 1, above 1 edge + drain 2.
- From the roll: backlash harm ("lightly toasted", level 1), spell out of control.
- Astral attention: the watcher reports, alert +1.
- Resistance: Ravn (hermetic) Intuition, Hush Body.

Clues to Veyrath

- **Ravn** recognises the grown dual barrier as decades of work: someone very old lives here.
- Vesna (Ravn's spirit) said the tower "has a heartbeat".
- **Hush's** strange trinket may show a vast shadow over the façade at the vault door.
- Don't hold back a truth the runners have earned.

Veyrath

REVEAL

- Appears only during or after the escape and speaks straight into the runners' minds with dragonspeech.
- **Seeing a dragon:** onlookers freeze up or flee unless they resist with Willpower. If he keeps his distance, a brief shock is enough.
- Dragons are dual-natured: their astral presence is visible from afar unless hidden. Veyrath hides his inside the tower.
- Judges, doesn't threaten, doesn't block. **Never a combat encounter.**

GM ONLY

Alert, Matrix & payoff

04

The alert clock shows what building security knows and does right now. It rises when an action plausibly draws attention, and drops when the fiction allows it.

Alert stages

6 SEGMENTS

- **0–1 Routine** event deviation. Standard patrols. Nobody searches.
- **2–3 Suspicion** cameras cross-check, doors demand re-auth, drones watch, staff are questioned.
- **4–5 Alarm** drones search, service routes closed, lifts stop or reroute, identified runners are tracked.
- **6 Lockdown** alarm confirmed, exits sealed, external response called.

How much alert?

TRIGGER	ALERT
minor complication: wrong area, watcher notices magic	+1
complication: identity checked and failed, drone report	+2
serious complication: door forced, gunfire, explosion	+3
action works directly on the clock	by effect

Not every failure raises alert. Harm, lost gear or a blocked door often fit better.

Lowering alert

Only through a concrete deed: a convincing explanation, old camera footage, a sensor passed off as a fault, a drone intercepted, a door log posing as maintenance, a party incident as an excuse. Success: alert drops by effect or a looming rise is cancelled.

Networked systems

SYSTEM	LEVER
Guest list, rosters	slip in names, forge a shift
Cameras	loop, old footage, angles
Lifts	stop, reroute, fake the floor
Door logs	pass access off as maintenance
Façade gondola	drive command, docking point 110
Drones	fool target recognition, orders, maintenance port
Skycab transponder 1/2/3	landing clearance on the roof

Offline

- **The briefcase** transmits nothing and can't be located via the Matrix. Offline means: only hackable by cable, directly at the device.
- **Keycard lockbox** in the event office: removal is logged, but the lock is physical.
- The **vault door** logs every attempt; a clean two-factor entry raises no alarm.

Matrix consequences

- ICe alerted or corners the hacker; next hack desperate.
- "Traced" clock: when full, the location is known. Going offline clears it but drops all control taken.
- Device damaged, shut down or jacked; target icon hidden.
- Usable trace: alert +1.
- Breach opens at once but alerts the system.

Repeated attempts only get harder when the fiction gives a reason.

Payoff

ALERT AT THE END	NUYEN
Low 0–1	6
Medium 2–5	5
High / lockdown 6	3

- Injured or dead guests or staff: at least as high alert.
- Venn seriously hurt or killed: clear breach of contract.
- Damage to the collection or extra loot can cut further.

Veyrath's verdict

RESULT	IF …
Ideal	briefcase closed, no loot, collection intact, Venn unharmed, little violence, teamwork
Usable	job done, but medium/high alert or avoidable escalation
Unfit	briefcase opened (even expertly), contents destroyed, Venn hurt, loot, indiscriminate killing